Social Cleavages and Party Systems

Comparative Politics

December 6-10, 2021

End-of-semester announcements!

- You will receive a **temporary** final grade on Monday, December 13 by 5:00 PM
- That grade will assume that your Quiz 5 score is the average of your previous 4 quizzes
- **This is not a real grade!** Just there to help you make decisions
- You have until Thursday, December 16 at 5:00 PM to decide if you want to take the final exam `(I will post a sign-up form on Canvas)`

Final exam

- Take home, open book essay, upload to Canvas as a PDF `(Find the link on the Modules section)`
- Only available to those who sign up
- You are automatically signed up if your final grade after quiz 5 is below **D-** `(67 points)`
- If you sign up, **your exam will be graded even if you don't submit!**
- **Available:** Friday, December 17, 5:00 PM
- **Due:** Tuesday, December 21, 11:59 PM `(You will get an incomplete if you submit late)`
- Choose 2 out of 3 questions to answer. 50 points each
- Focus on applying knowledge of course material to a political consulting scenario `(Show off what you have learned!)`

Participation grades

- Available along with temporary grades
- You have until December 17, 5:00 PM to dispute participation grades
- Send a one page document via email explaining why your grade should be better

Final grades

- **School deadlines:** December 23 for graduating students, January 5 for everyone else
- Will do my best to have final grades by December 23
- **Grade grievance procedure:** https://advising.tulane.edu/resources/policies-catalog

So far...

- We talked about how **parties** form governments to solve group-decision making problems in democracies
- We discussed how elections translate the votes that **parties** get into seats
- But what are **political parties**?
- **This week:** Where do they come from? What explains differences in party systems across the world?

Political parties

- **Political party:** Group of people including those who hold office and those who help them to get and remain there
- Political parties serve **four main purposes**:

  1. Structure the political world
  2. Recruit and socialize political elite
  3. Mobilize masses
  4. Serve as the link between rulers and ruled

- Because of their connection with elections and electoral systems, we say that **official political parties** are those recognized by law

Party systems

- **Nonpartisan democracy:** Democracy with no official parties
- **Single-party system:** Only one political party is legally allowed to hold power
- **One-party dominant system:** Multiple parties may legally operate but only one has a realistic chance of holding power
- **Two-party system:** Only two parties have a realistic chance of holding power
- **Multiparty system:** More than two parties have a realistic chance of holding power

- How do we know what counts as having a realistic chance to hold power?
- Any of the last three party systems can have 10 official parties
- But clearly not all parties count the same in each case!

Counting parties

- **Effective number of parties:** Use weights to count parties by both **number** and **size**
- **Effective number of electoral parties:** Number of parties that win votes

$$\frac{1}{\sum v_i^2}$$

- **Effective number of legislative parties:** Number of parties that win seats

$$\frac{1}{\sum s_i^2}$$

- v_i and s_i are the share of votes and seats, respectively

Example: Counting legislative parties

Party	A	B	C	D	E	Total
Seats	5	17	3	24	1	50
Share	0.1	0.34	0.06	0.48	0.02	1

$$
\begin{aligned}
ENLP &= \frac{1}{(0.1)^2 + (0.34)^2 + (0.06)^2 + (0.48)^2 + (0.02)^2} \\
&= \frac{1}{0.01 + 0.1156 + 0.0036 + 0.2304 + 0.0004} \\
&= \frac{1}{0.36} \\
&\approx 2.78
\end{aligned}
$$

Social cleavages

- We now know how to count parties and categorize the resulting party system
- But why do we have different parties to begin with?
- One of the roles of political parties is to represent **social cleavages**
- **Social cleavage:** Historically determined line which divides citizens within a society into groups with different political interests, resulting in conflict among these groups.

Common cleavages

- Urban-rural
- Confessional
- Secular-clerical
- Class
- Post-materialist
- Ethnic and linguistic

- **Why are some cleavages pronounced in some societies but not in others?**

Where do cleavages come from?

- Individuals have a repertoire of **attributes** that make them eligible for membership in some **identity category**
- Examples: Religion, language, class, gender, etc.
- Attributes are **fixed** in that most of the time we cannot change them and they are self-evident to others
- **Identity category:** Is a social group in which individuals can place themselves
- Identity categories are **socially constructed** in that they may or may not be **relevant depending on the context**

Running example: Chewas and Tumbukas in Malawi and Zambia

American Political Science Review Vol. 98, No. 4 November 2004

The Political Salience of Cultural Difference: Why Chewas and Tumbukas Are Allies in Zambia and Adversaries in Malawi

DANIEL N. POSNER *University of California, Los Angeles*

This paper explores the conditions under which cultural cleavages become politically salient. It does so by taking advantage of the natural experiment afforded by the division of the Chewa and Tumbuka peoples by the border between Zambia and Malawi. I document that, while the objective cultural differences between Chewas and Tumbukas on both sides of the border are identical, the political salience of the division between these communities is altogether different. I argue that this difference stems from the different sizes of the Chewa and Tumbuka communities in each country relative to each country's national political arena. In Malawi, Chewas and Tumbukas are each large groups vis-à-vis the country as a whole and, thus, serve as viable bases for political coalition-building. In Zambia, Chewas and Tumbukas are small relative to the country as a whole and, thus, not useful to mobilize as bases of political support. The analysis suggests that the political salience of a cultural cleavage depends not on the nature of the cleavage itself (since it is identical in both countries) but on the sizes of the groups it defines and whether or not they will be useful vehicles for political competition.

Puzzle

- $2/3$ of both Chewas and Tumbukas live in Malawi, $1/3$ live in Zambia
- **Malawi:** Political enemies
- **Zambia:** Political allies
- Other than being in different sides of the border, they are the exact same ethnic groups!

They even live around the border!

Cultural differences

- Chewas speak Chichewa, Tumbukas speak Chitumbuka
- Chewas dance nyau, Tumbukas dance vinbuza
- Chewa parents expect a chicken as dowry, Tumbuka parents expect seven cows

Political attitudes vary by country

- Would a member of your ethnic group vote for a presidential candidate from the other ethnic group?
  - **Zambia:** 21% no
  - **Malawi:** 61% no
- Would you marry a member from the other ethnic group?
  - **Zambia:** 24% no
  - **Malawi:** 55% no

Why allies in Zambia but enemies in Malawi

- Both countries have a SMDP electoral system
- Both have similar party systems
- Both former British colonies
- **So what explais the difference?**

Malawi

- Chewas (57%) and Tumbukas (12%)
- Given their size and electoral system, it makes sense to politicize the Chewa-Tumbuka division
- Malawi Congress Party (MCP) is seen as the Chewa party
- Alliance for Democracy (AFORD) is seen as the Tumbuka party

Zambia

- Chewas (7%) and Tumbukas (4%)
- Given the size and electoral system, it **does not** make sense to politicize the Chewa-Tumbuka division
- The main division is among Easterners (Chewas and Tumbukas), Northerners, Westerners, and Southerners
- A **regional** rather than **ethnic** cleavage
- Chewas and Tumbukas have to work together if they hope to win political power

What activates cleavages?

- The logic of political competition focuses elite and voter attention on some cleavages but not others
- Politicians seek build winning political coalitions
- Not all cultural and ethnic divisions become politicized
- **Electoral institutions** turn **latent** social cleavages into **politicized** social cleavages

Returning to the number of parties

- **Duverger's theory:** Social divisions are the primary driving force behind the formation of parties
- Electoral institutions influence how social divisions are translated into political parties
- The more **distinct** social cleavages there are, the greater demand for distinctive representation and political parties

Note: The textbook talks about **cross-cutting** instead of **distinct** cleavages. How does that matter?

The role of electoral institutions

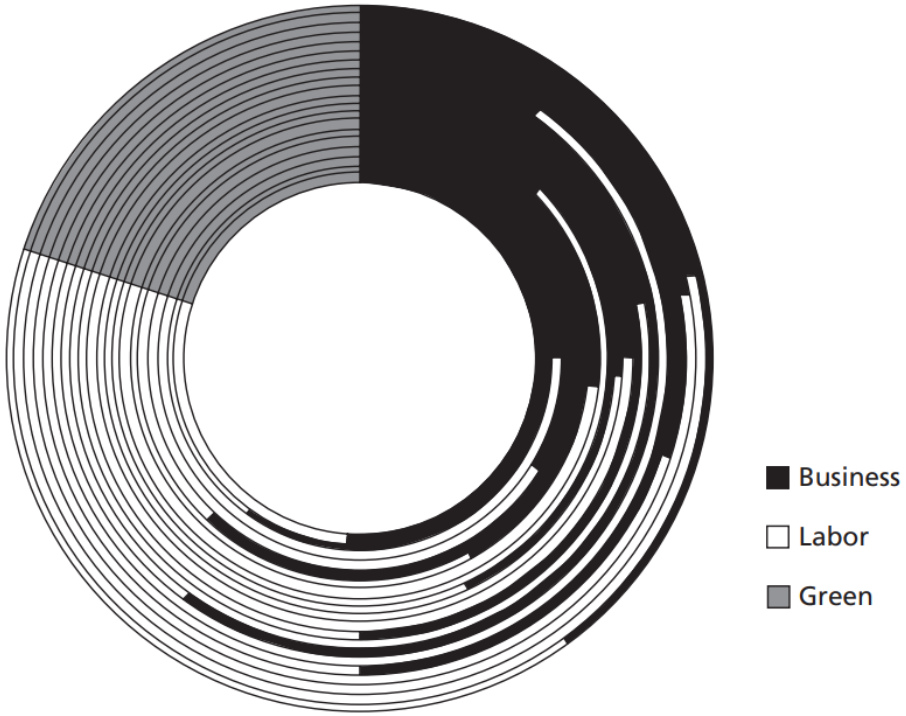
- Social cleavages create **demand** for political parties
- But electoral institutions determines **whether it makes sense** to meet the demand with supply
- **Least proportional electoral systems** act as a brake on the tendency for social cleavages to be translated into new parties
- **More proportional electoral systems** create incentives to politicize social cleavages
- So there is a **positive correlation** between the proportionality of the electoral system and the number of parties

Effects in Duverger's theory

- Two ways in which electoral systems affect the number of parties
- **Mechanical effect:**
  - The translation from votes to seats determines which and how many parties are viable
  - **Example:** SMDP tends to reward large parties, usually converging to two
- **Strategic effect:**
  - Knowledge of how the electoral formula works influences the strategic behavior of voters and political elites
  - **Example:** SMDP creates incentives to vote for the lesser evil

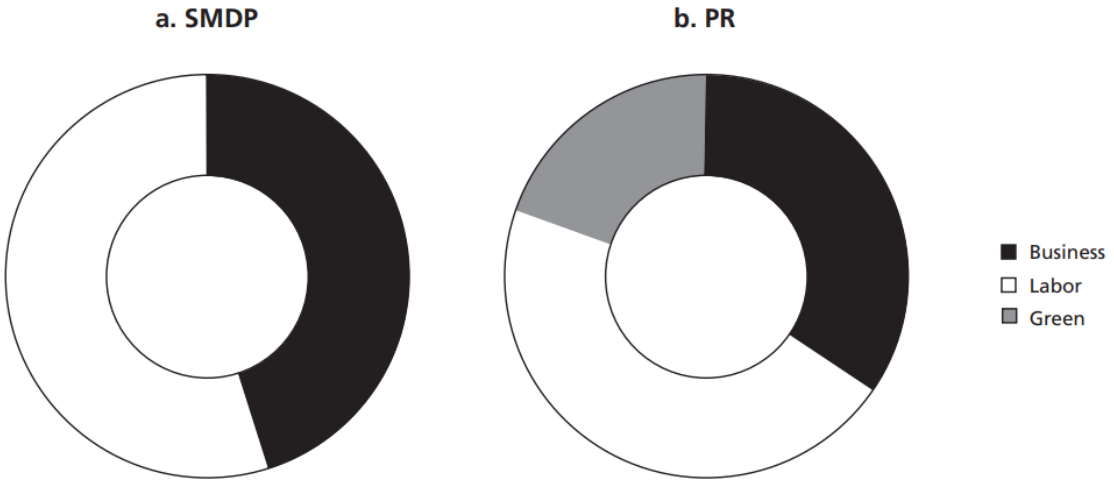
Mechanical effect: Duvergerland

FIGURE 14.2 **Duvergerland: A Hypothetical Country Using an SMDP Electoral System**



Mechanical effect: SMDP vs PR

FIGURE 14.3 **Distribution of Seats in Duvergerland under SMDP and PR Electoral Rules**



Strategic effect: Voting and entry

1. **Strategic voting:** Voting for the most preferred candidate or party **that has a realistic chance of winning**
2. **Strategic entry:** Political elites decide whether to enter the political scene under the label of their most preferred party **that has a realistic chance of winning**

- Notice that large parties are not always the ones more likely to win
- **Voters perspective:** A small party nationwide may be competitive in my district
- **Elite perspective:** A smaller party can focus more resources on your campaign

A caveat on Durverger's theory

- It only works at the district level!
- In average, we can have more parties competing at the national level than at the district level
- Even if district magnitude is constant across district!
- **Example:** Canada has around four major parties at the national level despite SMDP because different provinces have different two-party systems
- A party system is **nationalized** if the local and national party systems have similar size
- Nationalized party systems are **more common** under:

    1. Fiscal centralization
    2. Political centralization
    3. Concurrent presidential elections
    4. National cleavage patterns

Takeaways

- We can classify party systems depending on the number of parties
- But counting the **effective** number of parties is not trivial
- Latent social cleavages create demand for political representation
- Cleavages become politicized when parties choose to organize around them
- Electoral institutions and the distribution of distinct cleavages in society determines whether it makes sense to meet demand with supply
- This happens through the mechanical and strategic effects
- Sometimes district and national party systems look the same, sometimes they do not

Reminder:

News Report 5 due Friday by 5 PM

Next week:

Institutional Veto Players